



Lecture 1: Introduction to Psychology (PSY 101)

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Class Norms and Expectations

1. Attendance & Participation

- Being present in class regularly is important because psychology often involves discussions, reflections, and participation-based learning activities.

2. Open-mindedness and Respect

- Since psychology explores human thoughts, emotions, and behavior, everyone may have different perspectives.

You must respect differing views and avoid judgment.

3. Encouragement to Question and Reflect

- Psychology thrives on curiosity. Asking “*why*” behind behaviors and mental processes helps deepen understanding.

4. Confidentiality

- During class discussions or personal sharing, maintaining privacy is essential to build trust and respect among peers.
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Self-Reflection Before Beginning

Ask yourself:

- Why am I taking this course? (Interest, career, self-understanding?)
- What do I hope to learn? (About the brain, behavior, emotions?)
- How do I learn best? (Visually, auditorily, in groups, or independently?)

Self-awareness of your learning style can help you succeed in this course — just as psychology emphasizes self-understanding in general.



Course Overview

Psychology helps us understand **how and why humans think, feel, and behave** the way they do.

This course introduces both **scientific methods** and **theoretical foundations** of the field.

Major Topics:

1. **Introduction to Psychology** – What it is and why it matters.
 2. **The Brain** – Structure and biological functions affecting behavior.
 3. **Perception** – How we interpret sensory information.
 4. **Cognition** – Thinking, reasoning, memory, and language.
 5. **Emotion** – Feelings and their impact on actions.
 6. **Personality** – Individual differences and traits.
 7. **Development** – Growth from infancy to adulthood.
 8. **Psychopathology** – Psychological disorders and mental illness.
 9. **Social & Group Interactions** – How we behave with others in groups and society.
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Definition of Psychology

“Psychology is the **scientific study of behavior and mental processes.**”

Let’s break this down:

Term	Meaning
Scientific	Psychology uses systematic, objective, and empirical methods (e.g., experiments, observations, surveys) to gather verifiable data.
Behavior	Refers to observable actions like talking, walking, crying, eating — anything we can see or measure.
Mental Processes	Refers to internal experiences such as thoughts, emotions, memory, and motives that cannot be directly observed but can be inferred from behavior.

Example:

If someone suddenly cries, psychology tries to understand both the **behavior** (crying) and the **mental process** (sadness, loss, or stress) behind it.



History of Psychology



Ancient Origins

Humans have always wondered about the mind and soul.

- In **Ancient Egypt**, the *Edwin Smith Papyrus* (around 1600 BCE) contained one of the earliest recorded observations about the **brain’s role** in human functioning.
- Philosophers such as **Plato** and **Aristotle** in ancient Greece also debated the connection between the mind and body.



Birth of Experimental Psychology

- **1854 – Gustav Fechner (Germany):**

Developed the **first theory** on how humans make judgments about sensory experiences.

→ His work laid the foundation for **Signal Detection Theory**, which explains how we detect faint signals amid background noise.

- **1879 – Wilhelm Wundt (Germany):**

Founded the **first psychology laboratory** in Leipzig.

→ Marked the official beginning of psychology as a **scientific discipline**.

→ Wundt focused on **introspection**, where people described their conscious experiences in detail.

→ He was the **first person to identify as a psychologist**.



Development and Global Spread

- **G. Stanley Hall (1880s):**

- Established the first psychology lab in the **United States**.
- Promoted **scientific pedagogy** — applying psychology to education.

- **John Dewey (1890s):**

- Developed **educational theories** that emphasized **learning by doing** and adapting lessons to real-life experiences.
- Considered one of the fathers of modern education.



Behaviorism (Early 1900s)

- Founded by **John B. Watson**, later expanded by **B. F. Skinner**.
- **Main Focus:** Study only **observable and measurable behavior** — not thoughts or feelings.
- Introduced the idea of **conditioning**:
 - **Classical Conditioning:** Learning through association (Pavlov's dogs).
 - **Operant Conditioning:** Learning through **rewards and punishments** (Skinner).

Example:

A student studies hard to get praise (reward) → increases studying behavior.



Cognitive Revolution (Mid to Late 20th Century)

- Psychologists began to realize that **mental processes** (thinking, memory, problem-solving) were crucial.
- This led to the rise of **Cognitive Science**, combining multiple disciplines:
 - Cognitive Psychology
 - Linguistics
 - Computer Science
 - Philosophy
 - Neurobiology

 **Focus:** Understanding how we process information, think logically, store memories, and make decisions.



Major Perspectives in Psychology

Each perspective provides a different way to explain human behavior:

Perspective	Focus Area	Key Assumption / Example
Biological	Brain, hormones, and genetics	Behavior is influenced by biological structures and chemical processes. <i>Example:</i> Depression may be caused by low serotonin levels.
Behavioral	Learning from environment	Behavior is shaped through conditioning and reinforcement. <i>Example:</i> A child learns to say “thank you” after being praised.

Perspective	Focus Area	Key Assumption / Example
Cognitive	Mental processes	Focuses on how people think, understand, and remember. <i>Example:</i> Problem-solving or decision-making strategies.
Psychoanalytic	Unconscious motives	Founded by Freud; behavior is driven by unconscious desires and childhood conflicts. <i>Example:</i> Phobias may reflect repressed fears.
Humanistic	Free will and growth	Emphasizes human potential, self-actualization, and personal growth. <i>Example:</i> People strive to become the best version of themselves.
Socio-cultural	Society and culture	Behavior is influenced by social norms, traditions, and cultural expectations. <i>Example:</i> Collectivist vs. individualist cultures affect family roles.
Evolutionary	Adaptation and survival	Human traits evolved to enhance survival and reproduction. <i>Example:</i> Fear of snakes may be an evolved protective response.



Perception, Thinking, and the Stroop Effect



Automaticity

- When tasks become so familiar that they require **little conscious effort**.

Example: Reading is automatic — once you learn it, you don't need to think about every letter.*



Stroop Effect

- Demonstrates **interference between automatic and controlled processes**.

- Task: Name the **color** of the ink in which a word is printed rather than reading the word itself.

Example: The word “RED” written in blue ink.*

- People take longer or make mistakes because **reading (automatic)** interferes with **color recognition (controlled)**.
 - This experiment shows that **attention** and **processing speed** affect performance.
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Mental Health (According to WHO, 2022)

“Mental health is a state of mental well-being that enables people to cope with life’s stresses, realize their abilities, learn well and work well, and contribute to their community.”



Key Takeaways:

1. Mental health ≠ just the absence of mental illness.
→ It also means **positive psychological functioning**.
 2. Includes **emotional, psychological, and social well-being**.
→ How we feel, think, and relate to others.
 3. Influenced by **individual, social, and structural factors** — such as genetics, environment, and community support.
 4. Mental health can **change over time**, depending on life circumstances.
→ For instance, stress, loss, or trauma can affect well-being.
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Objectives of Psychology

Psychology aims to **understand and explain human thought and behavior** through the following:

- **Describe** how people behave.
- **Explain** why they behave that way.
- **Predict** future behavior based on observation.
- **Control or influence** behavior positively (e.g., therapy, education, workplace training).

It studies:

- How our **minds interpret sensory information** (what we see, hear, taste, feel).
- How we **think, learn, and remember**.
- How we **interact socially** and **make moral or emotional decisions**.



Subfields of Psychology

Subfield	Focus Area	Example
Biological Psychology	Links between brain, nervous system, and behavior	Studying how brain injuries affect memory.
Clinical Psychology	Diagnosis and treatment of mental disorders	Therapy for anxiety or depression.
Cognitive Psychology	Study of mental processes like perception, memory, reasoning	Research on how memory works.
Developmental Psychology	Growth and change across lifespan	Studying child development or aging.
Educational Psychology	Learning and teaching methods	Designing effective classroom strategies.
Social Psychology	Behavior in groups and social influence	Studying conformity or prejudice.

Subfield	Focus Area	Example
Industrial-Organizational Psychology	Behavior in workplace settings	Improving employee motivation and productivity.
Health Psychology	Connection between mind and physical health	Research on stress and its effects on the immune system.
Counseling Psychology	Helping individuals achieve personal well-being	Providing guidance for relationship or career issues.



In Summary

- **Psychology** = Science of **behavior and mental processes**.
 - It began as **philosophy**, became a **science** with Wundt in 1879, and evolved through **behaviorism** and **cognitive science**.
 - It includes multiple **perspectives** (biological, behavioral, cognitive, etc.), giving different explanations for human behavior.
 - It studies not only **mental illness** but also **positive mental health**, aiming to improve life quality.
 - Psychology applies to **education, health, relationships, workplaces, and society** as a whole.
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